



A PRABHAKAR RAO

Mumbai, Hyderabad and Kolkata but it has not provided them with new equipment. The force lacks helicopters to speedily transport them in case of an attack outside the city. Worse, qualitative requirements or the exact specifications for equipment, has not been drawn up for digital radio sets, night vision devices, night sights for weapons, bulletproof jackets and stun grenades.

"The force is fully equipped despite the constraints. We do not discuss procurements," says an NSG spokesperson. The files for equipment were cleared by the home minister within three months of 26/11 but mysteriously have not cleared the bureaucracy within the NSG. The NSG website mentions at least 12 items as being retendered.

Part of the reason for the delay is a cumbersome 12-stage process which takes up to six months to complete. Following the Delhi terror

attacks of September last year, the Home Ministry sanctioned the acquisition of four threat containment vessels (TCV)—mobile 1 tonne hemispheres where explosives can be destroyed—worth Rs 4 crore each. The NSG is yet to acquire them because the case is still stuck in bureaucracy. "If special forces are not given the special equipment, their contribution will be limited," says Ved Marwah, former director-general of the NSG.

CENTRAL PROBE AGENCY

FLAW The NIA is understaffed and without a permanent office

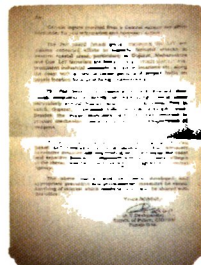
SOLUTION Beefing up force levels inducing more specialists

STORY SO FAR Only 45 officers on board of the proposed 95

4/10

The National Investigative Agency (NIA), hurriedly set up following the 26/11 attacks to investigate cases of terror across the country, is on the move, literally. Initially functioning from North Block, they moved to CGO Complex before being parked at Centaur Hotel. Here the NIA officials were busy negotiating with furniture sellers, deciding on interiors and haggling with hotel staff for secure phone lines. And just when they were settling in, they have been asked to move again, now to the CBI headquarters.

(CLOCKWISE FROM LEFT) THE NSG COMMANDOS AT THE HYDERABAD HUB; 26/11 MUMBAI ATTACK; THE TERROR ALERT



not have blast-proof eyewear, an item available off-the-shelf for just Rs 3,500. Troopers could not talk, shoot and advance because they did not have hands-free radios. Their walkie talkies kept running out of power because they were civilian models with just a four-hour charge as opposed to military models which keep ticking for twice as long.

Today the prestigious force finds even basic equipment like combat boots, knee pads and eye-protection wear have not been fast-tracked but put through the Government's slow tendering grind. The Home Ministry recently set up NSG hubs in Chennai,

CHIDAMBARAM'S REPORT CARD

Achievements

NSG hubs in Mumbai, Hyderabad, Kolkata and Chennai

14 interceptor boats delivered to coastal states

73 coastal police stations sanctioned; 59 are functional

3 cases given to NIA; sanctioned 123 posts

Sanctions given for acquisition of AGLs, thermal imagers

But...

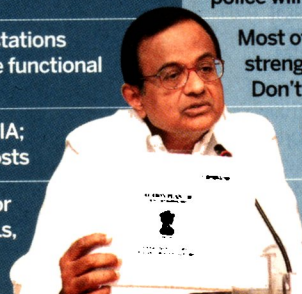
No special equipment yet for the prestigious force

Remaining 154 yet to be delivered. If shipyards don't deliver on time, police will still patrol in trawlers.

Most of them are not full strength coastal police stations. Don't have the manpower.

NIA operating with less than 50 per cent staff

Paramilitary still continues to be under-equipped



YASBANT NEGI